

PRIZE SCALP 'Chalapati' (inset), eliminated in a Jan. 21 encounter in Chhattisgarh, was a CPI (Maoist) 'Central Committee' member and a key figure in the insurgency for long

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MAOIST INSURGENCY

A BIG BODY BLOW

By Amarnath K. Menon

In the dense, unforgiving forests of Dandakaranya, where the line between predator and prey blurs with every rustle of leaves, a dramatic chapter in India's long-standing battle against left-wing extremism (LWE) has just been written. The killing of R.R. Pratap Reddy, a.k.a. Chalapati, a towering figure in the outlawed Communist Party of India (Maoist)'s Central Committee, marks not just the end of a man but a seismic shift in the insurgency's trajectory.

On January 21, the 62-year-old Maoist leader and 15 of his comrades—six women among them—were gunned down in a fierce encounter near the Udanti Sitanadi wildlife sanctuary, 160 kilometres east of Raipur, in Chhattisgarh's Gariaband district along the Odisha border. Chalapati had been steering Maoist activities in Odisha before he was finally trapped by a joint team of Chhattisgarh's District Reserve Guard, Odisha's Special Operations Group and the elite CoBRA unit of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF). For the security forces, neutralising a Central Committee member is no ordinary feat. These elusive figures, often described as the brain trust of the Maoist movement, have historically managed to defy capture, slipping through the cracks of central and east India's vast and rugged terrain.

The January 21 encounter is not an isolated event but part of a broader, intensified offensive against Maoist insurgency in Chhattisgarh. Since late 2023, the state has witnessed a surge in anti-Maoist operations, particularly in the Bastar region, the LWE epicentre in recent years. As many as 219 Maoists were killed in 2024—a huge uptick from just 20 killed the previous year. In January 2025 alone, 48 Maoists were killed in the state.

Chalapati's death is a body blow to the insurgents. Carrying a bounty of Rs 1 crore, he was not just another militant but a key strategist and a mentor to some of the most feared figures in the Maoist hierarchy. His journey from a district sericulture officer in Andhra Pradesh to a dreaded "military strategist" is a tale of ideological fervour and ruthless ambition. Born in Andhra's Chittoor district, Chalapati started as an ideologue before getting arms training in Odisha's Koraput district and later turning into a weapons instructor for the cadre. By the 1980s, he had gone underground, trading his government jeep for an AK-47 and his office for the dense forests along the Andhra-Odisha border. One of his most infamous mentees is Madvi Hidma, who commands Battalion No. 1 of the CPI (Maoist)'s armed wing, the People's Liberation Guerrilla Army. It is responsible for some of the deadliest ambushes in the insurgency's history, including the 2010 Dantewada attack that killed 76 CRPF personnel.

TERMINAL DECLINE

↘ With Chalapati gone, the CPI (Maoist) 'Central Committee' shrinks to 19 members: 12 of Telangana origin, two of Andhra. Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh account for the rest. No. in 2004: 32

↘ Its politburo, too, left with just 4 members, including 2 from Telangana, where the insurgency is largely inactive